# DAY ZERO

*The lights go out. Nobody has the whole picture.*



**1–8** Players | **40–75** Minutes | **Co-op** Family

## Rules of Play

*a game by Non Native Entrepreneur*

# Welcome to Mill Lane

The whole of Kelderwick has gone dark. It is November, the night is cold, and somebody is knocking on the door of the Mill Lane community hall: *"Is anyone organising things here?"*

You are. In **Day Zero** you and your family play the neighbours who keep the hall going through a long, cold week without power. Everyone is on the same side, but nobody knows everything. Each of you holds different information, and some of it is only rumour.

The game is played on a shared screen, a TV or a laptop, and told **Day by Day.** What you decide today turns up in tomorrow's news, and the street remembers.

Along the way you will meet **Kit**, the kid in the yellow raincoat who runs every message; **Marta**, who knows everyone in Hillside; **Sam**, who repeats everything his radio tells him; **Ines**, **Theo** and **Pavel.**



*The first knock at the hall door.*

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## *I*
# Components

*Day Zero has no board and no cards. Everything happens on screen. You will need:*

**One shared screen**
A TV, laptop or tablet that everyone can see, with internet.

**Phones (optional)**
One each, as private controllers. This is beta and hasn't been tried on real phones yet.

**This booklet**
Read pages 4–6 aloud the first time you play.

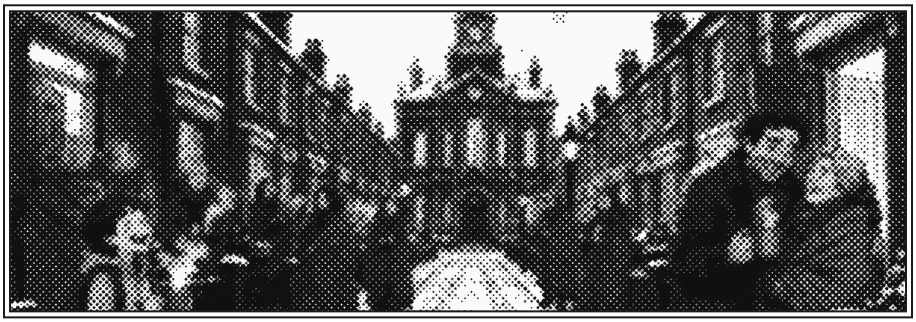
**A pencil**
For the Playtest Report on page 11.

## *II*
# Object of the Game

Keep Mill Lane together until the power comes back. You win **stars** for three things: getting the hall's **Hub** running (Warmth, Water and Information), keeping people **healthy**, and keeping the street **united**.

Problems arrive with **clocks.** Each night, an unsolved clock fills a little, and when it fills something bad happens. Talk, share what you know, and choose well. If **Health** or **Cohesion** ever falls to nothing, the week ends early.

Warmth Water Information



*The morning the lights came back.*

*III*

# Setting Up



*Gathering round the map in the hall.*

1. **Open the game** on the shared screen and go full screen (F11). The link is on the back cover.

2. **Who is playing?** Type each name. Tick the child box beside anyone aged about 7–11. For more than four players, open **5–8 players**.

3. **Choose a length.** **full story · 7 days** takes about 60–75 minutes. **quick game · 5 days** takes about 40.

4. **Choose the screens** under **game options**:
   - **TV only**, the default. Everything is on one screen.
   - **TV + phone briefings.** Players scan a code to read their private cards. No connection is needed.
   - **TV + phone controllers** (beta). Phones vote and act. Every device needs internet.

   Leave **Personal goals** and **Secret votes** on, and leave **The Insider** off for a family game.

5. **Press play.** With phone controllers, each player scans *the code beside their own name*. When every badge reads **connected**, press **start day 1**.

**Starting again?** Use **play** for a fresh game. **continue saved game** picks up where you left off.

## *IV*
# The Day

*Four phases, always in the same order. The track at the top of the screen shows where you are.*

I



### Morning News

A short *Previously…* recap, today's headline and the **big question** of the Day. It also shows the problems and their clocks. Sometimes a **Crossroads** card asks one player to decide on the spot. The **coordinator**, named on screen and changing every Day, reads it aloud.

*When you're ready, press* **DISCUSS: WHAT DO YOU EACH KNOW?**

II



### Discuss

Everyone reads their own role cards, on the TV or privately on a phone. Some cards are **verified** and some are only **rumours**. Say what you know out loud, because nobody has the whole picture.

*When you're ready, press* **WE'VE TALKED · DECIDE**

III



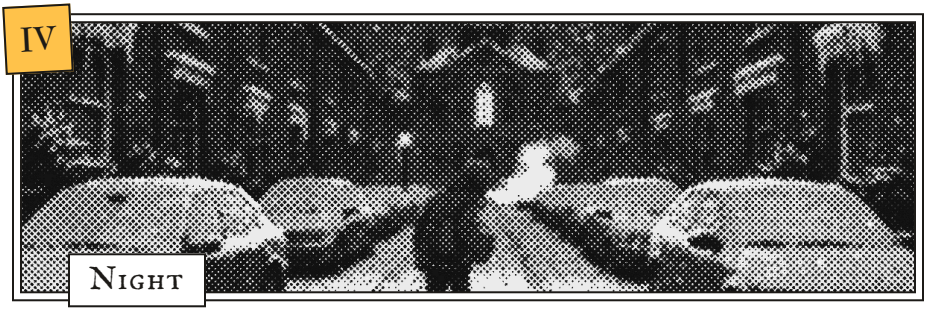
## Decide

First, the Day's big decision. Hold a **secret vote** by passing the device round, or by voting on phones, or decide together on the screen. The majority wins, and a tie goes to the role that owns the decision. If three or more of you agree, Cohesion goes up by one.

Then each role picks its **actions**: one on Day 1, two after that, and always one for the kid roles. They all happen together at night, so if one action needs another, choose both.

*When you're ready, press* **lock in & let night fall**

IV



## Night

A short story of what happened: what worked, what was blocked, and how the clocks moved while you slept. A full clock causes harm. The night ends on a **cliffhanger** for tomorrow's news.

*When you're ready, press* **next morning**

### The street remembers

The choices still in play appear under **Remembered** on the track. For example, open the hall's stores and there is a queue at the door next morning. In the Full story, how you treat Hillside on Day 3 decides whether the old mill path is open on the coldest night. The Quick game skips that Day and Day 5, *The Rumour*.

# V
# The Roles

*Each role sees different cards and has its own actions. With one to four players, these four roles are shared out among you.*



## Theo *the Signal*

*19, never takes his headphones off.*

Checks rumours, makes broadcasts, calls the emergency services and runs the hall's radio. You decide what is true.

Spends Signal

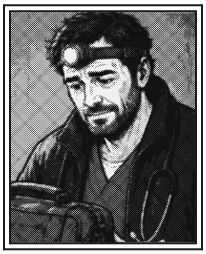


## Ines *the Quartermaster*

*46, runs the community hall.*

Drives the van, delivers fuel, fetches food, wood and water, and sets up the generator. Almost every plan needs the van.

Spends Fuel

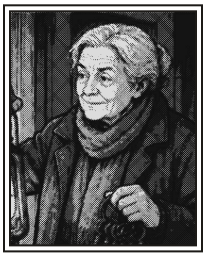


## Pavel *the Medic*

*38, a night-shift nurse.*

Treats people, climbs to Mr Aldous and cares for the most vulnerable. Spots the deadly mistakes before they happen.

Spends Medkits



## Marta *the Local*

*74, has lived on Mill Lane for 46 years.*

Talks to the caretaker, the shop owners and the depot, and opens doors that others can't. Holds the maps.

Spends Contacts

## VI
# Bigger Tables & Younger Players

*With five to eight players, four more roles join the game in this order.*

**Kit**, the Runner KID ROLE
One quick job a Day: running messages, handing out torches, carrying water up the tower. No costs.

**Bea**, the Host KID ROLE
One kind job a Day: tea and biscuits, stories for the little ones, blankets. No costs.

**Dev**, the Mechanic
Fixes things with tools rather than Fuel: the generator, the pump and the radio mast.

**Grace**, the Liaison
Uses official channels: the council, the warden and the depot gate.



*Kit brings Hillside's empty bottles to the hall.*

**Younger players.** With five or more players, anyone ticked as a child gets Kit or Bea first. Kid roles have short, simple cards, no rumours, and never see Insider or sabotage text.

**Private goals.** After Day 1, each player gets a quiet goal of their own. These are revealed and scored in the Chronicle. **The Insider** is optional and is for three or more players aged 12 and up.

*VII*

# Winning and Losing

*There is no simple win or lose. When the week ends, the* ***Mill Lane Chronicle****, a newspaper front page about your game, awards up to* ***nine stars****.*

| | ★★★ | ★★ | ★ |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Mission**<br>Warmth, Water, Information | All three running | Two of them | One or none |
| **People**<br>Health | 5 or more | 3–4 | 1–2 |
| **Community**<br>Cohesion + Trust | 8 or more | 5–7 | 4 or less |

*Eight or nine stars earns the best ending: "The Lights of Mill Lane".*

### Losing early

If **Health** or **Cohesion** drops to 0, the game ends at once with one of the sad endings, *The Ambulances at Dawn* or *Every House for Itself*.

### The Crisis meter

⧖ The Crisis meter rises every night, and again whenever a problem's clock fills. If it fills up (10 on Normal, 12 on Easy, 9 on Hard), the story jumps straight to the last Day.

### What you count

The town keeps **Supplies**, **Health**, **Cohesion** and **Trust**, each from 1 to 6. The roles spend **Fuel**, **Signal**, **Medkits** and **Contacts**.

Afterwards, **show what you missed** reveals which rumours were true.

**The town**

Supplies · Health · Cohesion · Trust

**The roles**

Fuel · Signal · Medkits · Contacts

*VIII*

# Notes for the Host

Read the Morning News aloud like a storyteller, and let the coordinator lead. Don't explain beyond what the screen says. Its tips teach the rules as they come up, and the first decision arrives within a couple of minutes.

Let the younger players press the buttons and read out the cliffhangers. Write down every "what do we do now?", because those are the most useful notes of all.

At the end, read the Chronicle together, then press **SHOW WHAT YOU MISSED**.

### If the phones won't connect

- If the lobby says the phone link isn't working, press **PLAY WITHOUT PHONES**. The whole game runs on the TV.
- If one phone is stuck, use **VOTE ON THIS SCREEN** or **SHOW THEIR CARDS HERE** for that player.
- If a phone fell asleep, scan the same code again to rejoin.
- Strict Wi-Fi can block the link, so try mobile data. Or, before you start, choose **TV only** or **TV + phone briefings**.



*Theo at the radio desk.*

### What to watch for

Where people got confused · which choices started arguments · whether the story pulled them in · whether the phones connected, and which phone and browser · any bugs or frozen screens · how long it took.

*IX*

# Playtest Report

*Fill this in during and straight after the game.*

Date _____ Players & ages _____

Full / Quick _____ Screens _____

Start time _____ First decision _____

End time _____ Stars & ending _____

Where did people get confused? Which screen, and what did they say?

Which choices started an argument? Did the story pull them in?

Phones: which model and browser, and did they connect? Any bugs or frozen screens?

### Afterwards, ask everyone, children too

1. How much fun was it, from one to five?
2. Which choice was the hardest to make, and why?
3. Who was your favourite character, and what was the best moment?
4. Would you play again? What one thing would you change?

# DAY ZERO

*The power is out across Kelderwick. The freezers are thawing, the taps are coughing, and Mr Aldous's breathing machine is beeping on the ninth floor. Can your table keep Mill Lane together until the lights come back?*



## PLAY NOW

`raw.githack.com/NNEyt/dayzero/story-days/index.html`

Open it on the TV or laptop. Phones join later by scanning the codes on screen.